

# NEU/NYP Archive Project

## A proposal to the Unit Chief

September 29, 2026 · Prepared by **Josh**

### Purpose

The Unit's archive room holds records and media that exist nowhere else, and some of that material is degrading on a fixed clock. This proposal offers to digitize it, catalog it, and publish an approved portion as a public archive site. It is offered as volunteer work.

Four outcomes:

- **Preserve** the at-risk formats first. Film, slides, and magnetic tape fail in ways paper does not.
- **Catalog** every item into a searchable database, with a full copy delivered to the Unit.
- **Publish** only what the Unit approves, through a review gate the Unit holds.
- **Tell the stories** — feature pieces in the model of the Iron Mike story, plus structured ways for retirees, families, and current crews to contribute.

The ask at the end of this document is deliberately small: permission to survey the room and run one pilot batch under signed custody paperwork, then meet and decide whether anything continues.

### What is in the room today

What follows comes from a short visit, not a survey, so treat it as an impression of the room rather than an account of it. Establishing what is actually on each shelf — in what format and in what condition — is the first deliverable of this project, and that written inventory has standalone value to the Unit even if nothing else here proceeds.

From what was visible, the holdings appear to run across these kinds of material:

| Category                      | Typical material                                         |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Incident records              | ICS packets, 209s, 214s, unit logs, IAPs                 |
| Station and battalion records | Daily logs, station histories, rosters, correspondence   |
| Photographs                   | Prints, negatives, contact sheets                        |
| Slides                        | 35mm transparencies                                      |
| Moving image                  | 16mm reels, VHS, possibly Betacam or U-matic             |
| Maps and plans                | Fire maps, pre-plans, station drawings, oversized sheets |
| Apparatus and equipment       | Engine and dozer records, photographs, specifications    |
| Publications                  | Newsletters, clippings, training material, memorabilia   |

The room is inside a secured area, which shapes the whole handling question addressed further down. Nothing in this proposal requires unescorted access or access to any other part of the facility.

## Why some of this is urgent and most of it is not

Paper in a dry, stable room can wait another twenty years. Film, slides, and magnetic tape cannot, and that asymmetry is the single most important fact in this proposal.

- **Acetate film** breaks down into acetic acid — "vinegar syndrome." Once it starts it accelerates, and it is not reversible.
- **Color slides and prints** lose their dyes, which is why 1970s and 1980s fire photos so often look orange.
- **Videotape** sheds its magnetic layer onto the playback heads. A tape can often be played once more, and not twice.
- **Playback hardware and vendors** are disappearing. Fewer shops every year can transfer 16mm or Betacam at archival quality.

So the moving-image and slide material gets triaged early, even though paper is the bulk of the collection and the easier win. That is why the phasing below does film and tape before finishing the paper.

## What the public would see

This would be a real catalog, not a folder of PDFs on a web server — fast, searchable, and as usable on a phone as on a desktop.

What a visitor can do:

- **Search everything**, including the text inside scanned documents, which are run through OCR on ingest.
- **Browse by incident, station, battalion, or year** — pick a fire by name and see every document, photo, and map tied to it in one place.
- **View media properly** — deep-zoom on scans and photographs, an inline player for transferred film and video.
- **Read feature stories** — curated pieces built from the archive. The Iron Mike story is the model and the proof the format works.

It would be a progressive web app: loads fast, works on bad cell service, pins to a phone home screen. Nothing about it runs on agency infrastructure or touches the agency network.

## Precedent: this has been done before

This is a well-worn path, not an experiment. Comparable efforts, all of them public agency records made public:

| Agency or project                                | What they did                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Indianapolis Fire Department</b>              | Log books, dispatch recordings, personnel records, newsletters, and photographs back to the 1870s, digitized in partnership with the Indianapolis Public Library and published on its Digital Indy site — roughly 80,000 scans and 4,660 staff hours |
| <b>Los Angeles County Fire Museum</b>            | Early L.A. County Fire Department papers scanned at high resolution with OCR into searchable PDFs, through a commercial digitization partner                                                                                                         |
| <b>Seattle Fire Department</b>                   | Department central files, 1890–2003, described and served through the Seattle Municipal Archives digital collections                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>U.S. Forest Service</b>                       | "Hidden Photo History of the Forest Service and Wildland Fire, 1910–2010" — roughly 5,000 photographs plus 8mm and 16mm film, covering the 1910 fires, early California air patrols, and Mann Gulch                                                  |
| <b>National Museum of Forest Service History</b> | A dedicated wildland fire history repository, now anchored by a new conservation legacy center in Missoula                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>California Revealed</b>                       | A California State Library program that digitizes, preserves, and hosts archival and audiovisual material for local libraries, archives, museums, and historical societies — over 200 partners statewide                                             |

Two things worth pulling out of that list.

First, none of these appear to have produced a privacy incident. The model is established and the safeguards are known, which is most of why the next sections are as specific as they are.

Second, **California Revealed is worth a phone call regardless of what happens with this proposal.** It is State Library funded, it specializes in exactly the at-risk film and tape formats sitting in that room, and digitization is free to partner organizations. The usual route in is a partnership with a public library or historical society rather than a direct agency application — so it is not a replacement for this proposal, but it is a real preservation path for the most fragile material, and it costs the Unit nothing to ask.

## How the collection is organized

Two structures doing two different jobs. The hierarchy records where something came from. The facets let a retired captain find the one fire he remembers.

*[ Figure: archive structure · four levels of description, six cross-cutting facets — see the online version of this document ]*

The hierarchy follows standard archival practice — provenance and original order are preserved, so an item's context survives digitization. A worked path reads:

NEU/NYP Archive → Stations → Station 20 → Photographs → item NEU-2026-00417

The facets are where the real work happens for a fire unit. Almost nobody arriving at this archive is looking for "Series: Incident Records." They are looking for a fire by name, a station they were assigned to, a year, an engine number, or a person. Every item carries as many facets as are known, and any combination of them is a valid search.

Series are described consistently across record groups, so a photograph from HQ is cataloged the same way as one from a station. That consistency is what makes cross-cutting search work at all.

## How material moves in and out

The proposal is a small-batch loan with a signed receipt in both directions, and no more than a few boxes out of the room at any one time. The design goal is that at every moment, the Unit can say exactly what is out, who has it, and when it is due back.

1. **Request.** I identify a batch from the survey — two to four boxes, or one media tote — and send the proposed contents to the Unit point of contact for approval.
2. **Pickup.** The Unit representative and I sign a Custody Receipt listing containers and contents at folder level. I photograph each container as received, including any existing damage.
3. **Storage and work.** One controlled indoor location, no third-party access, nothing loaned onward, nothing left in a vehicle. Scanning on my own equipment. Original order preserved — nothing unstapled, trimmed, or reordered without specific permission.
4. **Return.** Within the agreed window, typically two to four weeks. Both parties sign the return side of the same receipt, and I attach a **Returned Batch Report**: what was scanned, what was too fragile and why, what was found that the manifest did not list, and anything that arrived already damaged.
5. **Next batch.** Nothing new leaves until the previous batch is back and signed in. One batch out at a time keeps the accounting trivial.

**If the Chief prefers that nothing leaves the building,** I will work on-site with a portable scanner during agreed windows. It is slower, it needs a place to set up, and somebody has to let me in and out — which is the personnel draw I am trying to avoid. I will work either way; the small-batch loan is simply the version that costs the Unit less.

## The paperwork that makes custody defensible

The closest familiar analogy is **chain of custody** — the evidence transfer model, where every hand-off is signed, timed, and traceable. That instinct is correct, and the mechanism proposed here works the same way. But evidence rules are not the right legal vehicle for archival records, so the instruments below are the ones actually used for this kind of work.

| Instrument                   | What it does                                                                                                                                 | Who signs       |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Volunteer Services Agreement | Establishes me as an authorized volunteer of the Unit for this project, with a defined scope                                                 | Unit, volunteer |
| Memorandum of Understanding  | States the project's purpose, boundaries, deliverables, the Unit's approval authority, ownership of the output, and how the arrangement ends | Unit, volunteer |
| Temporary Custody Agreement  | Governs off-site work: storage conditions, transport, insurance or liability position, duration, prohibition on onward transfer              | Unit, volunteer |

| Instrument                              | What it does                                                                                | Who signs                            |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Custody Receipt / Transfer of Materials | Per-batch, signed at pickup and again at return — the chain-of-custody log for this project | Unit rep, volunteer, both directions |
| Returned Batch Report                   | Attached to each return: what was scanned, what was not, what was found, condition notes    | Volunteer, acknowledged by Unit rep  |

Four points that matter to the Chief:

- **These stay State records.** Nothing here transfers ownership. Under the State Records Management Act and CAL FIRE's retention schedule the Unit remains custodian of record. I hold temporary physical custody, and a digital copy is a copy — not a replacement.
- **Nothing is destroyed, discarded, or reorganized.** If I think something should be reboxed or rehoused, I say so in the batch report and leave it alone. Disposition belongs to the Unit and its records coordinator.
- **Attach to what already exists, and have it reviewed.** CAL FIRE already has volunteer instruments and a records management structure, and hanging this off those is faster and less exposed than drafting something new. The framing above is practical, not legal advice — the records coordinator and legal should approve the final documents before the first box moves.

One thing to confirm before anything moves: whether any of it is under a litigation hold, an open investigation, or a retention obligation that puts it off-limits. That is a Unit call, and the survey is where it would surface.

## What gets published, and what does not

Everything is ingested private by default, and only the Unit can make something public. I do not hold the release decision, and the system is built so that I cannot accidentally hold it.

Old fire records routinely contain material that should not go on a public website:

- Personnel information — evaluations, discipline, medical, home addresses, Social Security numbers on older forms
- Patient and EMS detail in incident records
- Civilian names, addresses, and property loss detail
- Arson and cause-and-origin investigation material, including closed cases
- Images of fatalities or serious injury, and anything touching ongoing litigation or claims

The pipeline that handles it:

1. **Ingest private.** Every item lands with review status **unreviewed**, visible only to authenticated project accounts.
2. **First-pass flag.** I flag anything matching the categories above, plus anything I am unsure about. Unsure defaults to flagged.

3. **Unit review.** A Unit-designated reviewer works an approval queue — approve, withhold, or approve with redaction. A few clicks per item, at their own pace, and nothing expires waiting.
4. **Publish.** Only approved items become publicly visible. Where one name or address is the only problem, the public copy can be masked and the unredacted master stays private.
5. **Takedown path.** A visible contact route for anyone — family, retiree, employee — to ask that an item be pulled. Pulled first, discussed after.

Borderline items escalate through the Unit's own channels — PIO, records coordinator, or Sacramento as the Chief directs. The California Public Records Act exemptions that would apply to a records request apply just as much to a voluntary publication, and the conservative reading wins. A withheld item is still preserved and still cataloged for the Unit, which is most of the value here regardless.

## Protected health information and personnel records: never published

Two categories are structurally excluded from the public site, regardless of the age of the record.

**Protected health information.** Patient names, ages, addresses, conditions, treatment, and transport destinations; any EMS or medical narrative inside an incident record; anything that would identify a person receiving care. Where PHI sits inside an otherwise publishable document — a patient name written on an incident report — the public copy is redacted and the unredacted master stays private. No medical information about any member of the public or any employee is published, ever.

**Personnel and HR information.** Performance evaluations, discipline, complaints and investigations, grievances, workers' compensation and injury records, medical and fitness-for-duty files, home addresses, personal phone numbers, dates of birth, and the Social Security numbers that appear on older forms. Employment information about sworn members appears only where it is already public record, and only in a historical, non-derogatory context — a roster, a promotion, a retirement, a commendation.

These are not reviewer judgment calls made item by item. They are exclusions applied at ingest: the material is withheld entirely or redacted before anything reaches a public URL. HIPAA where it applies, the Information Practices Act, and the CPRA personnel and medical exemptions all point the same direction, and where the reading is ambiguous the item stays private. Nothing gets published to settle an argument about whether an exemption technically applies.

## How the platform enforces it

The site runs on Supabase — Postgres with authentication, authorization, and storage access control built in. The safeguards that matter here:

- **Row Level Security.** Every item carries a review status, and the database itself decides what an anonymous visitor may read. The default is deny. An item becomes publicly readable only after a Unit reviewer has explicitly approved it. A bug in the website cannot leak an unapproved record, because the public role has no permission to see it in the first place.
- **Separate public and private storage.** Public derivatives live in a public bucket. Masters, unredacted originals, and anything unreviewed live in a private bucket reachable only through a short-lived signed URL issued to an authenticated account. Nothing sensitive sits behind a guessable link.

- **Encryption and backups.** Encrypted in transit and at rest, with automated backups and point-in-time recovery. Master files are additionally kept on offline storage I control, so a platform problem is not a data loss event.
- **Named accounts, no shared logins, full audit trail.** Every approve, withhold, and redact action is attributed to a named person with a timestamp. If anyone ever asks who released a given document, the answer is on record.
- **Withheld means invisible, not merely unavailable.** A withheld item does not appear in the public catalog or the public search index at all. The site does not advertise the existence of a sealed file.

A withheld item is still fully described in the Unit's private catalog, which is where its value to the Unit lives anyway.

## How this relates to public records requests

Worth stating first, because it is easy to blur: **this project has no standing under the Public Records Act.** It is not a state agency, the site is not an official CAL FIRE property, and it can neither receive nor answer a records request. The Act bears on it in two indirect ways, and both are reasons to address it rather than ignore it.

**It is the test the Unit would be applying.** When a Unit reviewer approves or withholds an item here, the exemptions they are reasoning from are the Department's: the published guidelines cite Government Code sections 7922.000 and 7927.000 et seq. The standard for publishing something voluntarily should not be looser than the standard for releasing it on request. Where this project is unsure, it withholds and lets the Unit decide.

**It is the door a member of the public should be using instead of this site.** CAL FIRE's process runs under Government Code section 7920.000 et seq.: requests go through the CAL FIRE Public Records Center on the GovQA portal, or in writing to the CAL FIRE Legal Office, PO Box 944246, Sacramento, CA 94244-2460 — handled by the Department's Legal Office, not by the Unit. An unofficial site that looks institutional is precisely the thing someone might mistake for a department channel, so it should link there plainly rather than leave somebody emailing a volunteer about a formal request.

Two further things follow from reading those guidelines.

**Patient care reports are already a named category.** The guidelines describe medical records requests as covering patient care reports generated during emergency incidents, including patient history, assessments, treatments administered and transport. That is the Department's own position, and it is why a patient care report is withheld in full here rather than redacted — an incident packet with a PCR attached is not a document to mask a few fields on.

**Publishing reduces request volume.** The Department charges ten cents a page for copies, and staff time goes into locating and reviewing the records first. A routine historical request — a station's history, an old incident's maps, a photograph of an apparatus — currently costs somebody an afternoon. If the non-exempt part of that material is already online and searchable, those requests get answered with a link. That is a modest argument for this project that has nothing to do with history: it moves work off the Legal Office.

One caveat to raise with the records coordinator rather than assume: the guidelines state that records are not removed from the Department's possession and that an employee is present during inspection. Those provisions govern public inspection under the Act rather than internal handling, and the custody arrangement proposed here is an internal departmental decision rather than a CPRA inspection — but that distinction is for the records coordinator and legal to confirm. It is exactly the kind of thing worth settling before the first box moves.

## Automated flagging on ingest

Thousands of pages will pass through this project, and expecting a reviewer to catch every Social Security number on a 1970s form is how things get missed. So every page is read by an automated sensitivity pass on ingest, before it reaches the review queue.

**The pass can only restrict.** It flags, it can propose a redaction, and it can escalate an item to withheld. It cannot approve anything, cannot clear anything, and cannot remove a flag a human has set. A model that could mark records safe for release would be a liability; one that can only raise its hand is a net.

**Screening runs on my own machine, and nothing leaves it.** Two passes: a pattern pass for the structured identifiers — Social Security numbers, dates of birth, phone numbers, addresses, medical vocabulary — and an open-weights model running locally for person names and for telling one kind of document from another. Sending a page to an outside service in order to find out whether it contains protected health information would mean that information had already left the building.

**To be plain about what "automated" means here.** The local passes above are not Claude or any other hosted assistant. Those services run in a vendor's data centre and cannot be installed on a laptop, so anything they read has to be sent to them over the internet. The screening described above deliberately uses tooling that does not do that.

**Using a hosted model such as Claude is a separate decision, and it is the Unit's to make.** It would be markedly better than local tooling at the judgment local tooling is worst at — telling a crew roster from a discipline file, reading a medical narrative written in prose, making sense of bad handwriting. The cost is that document text leaves the building. The protections that exist for this are real but have to be obtained in writing rather than assumed: Anthropic's commercial terms do not permit training on material sent through the API and delete it by default within thirty days, zero-retention agreements are available, and HIPAA-ready access under a signed business associate agreement is the arrangement that matters where protected health information is involved. My recommendation is to run the pilot entirely locally, so the Unit can see the work with nothing leaving its custody, and to treat a hosted model as a second-phase question once there is something concrete to judge. It stays switched off until the Unit says otherwise in writing.

**Every flag is auditable.** Each one records the rule or model that raised it, its version, the page and character range, a confidence score, and a timestamp — so a reviewer can see why an item was flagged, and the Unit can spot-check whether the pass is any good.

**It will miss things.** OCR on handwritten carbon copies is poor, and a name the pass cannot read is a name it cannot flag. It sees text, not context: the same name is unremarkable on a promotion announcement and sensitive on a complaint file. It does not look at photographs at all, so a street number on a mailbox or a plate in frame will not be caught. During the pilot I would hand-label a sample of pages and report what the pass actually caught and, more usefully, what it missed — a flagging tool with no measured miss rate is a comfort

blanket.

So the default does not change. Unreviewed still means private, and nothing is published because a model said it was fine. The pass shortens the queue and highlights what to look at; it does not remove the human step.

**AI-assisted search, if there is budget for it**

Keyword search finds documents; it does not answer questions. A retrieval agent reads the approved records, answers in a few sentences, and cites the records it used so a researcher can check it. This is the one feature in this proposal with a cost per use, so it comes last and it is genuinely optional.

**It searches as the person asking, not as itself.** The agent holds no account and no standing access. Every query runs under the asker's own permissions, against the same row-level rules. A member of the public asking a question gets an agent that can read exactly the approved records they could have opened themselves. There is no privileged path.

**Withheld material stays invisible to it, including its existence.** When the answer would live in a withheld record, the agent does not report that a sealed document exists — it reports that the catalog holds nothing on the subject, because from where it is standing that is true. An agent that could confirm the existence of withheld material would leak exactly what the gate protects. It also cannot distinguish a record that was never created from one that is not public, and it says so rather than implying.

**No citation, no claim.** Every statement of fact carries a record identifier. Where the records do not support an answer, the required response is to say the archive does not establish it. Gaps are findings, not failures — an archive whose search invents a date is worse than an archive with no search.

**It is read-only.** It cannot approve, withhold, flag, redact, catalog or edit anything. The ingest pass and the review gate are untouched by it.

**The cost, honestly.** A question means sending retrieved record text to a model and getting a short answer back. At current list prices that is roughly two cents a question on a small model, about five on a mid-sized one, under ten on the largest — so a few hundred questions a month is a low tens of dollars, and prompt caching on the fixed instructions reduces it further. It would run under a hard monthly ceiling: when the ceiling is reached the feature switches off and says so rather than quietly continuing to spend, and ordinary search carries on working because ordinary search is free. Those are list prices and will change, so treat them as an order of magnitude rather than a quote.

This is also the most sensible thing to point a fundraiser at, if there ever is one, because unlike the rest of the project its cost is legible and it degrades gracefully to nothing.

**What this asks of the Unit**

The total ongoing ask is on the order of an hour a month from one person, and it is the part of this proposal I have worked hardest to keep small.

| What                                                                                     | Roughly how much                                       |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Escorted access to the archive room — for the survey first, then for pickups and returns | Two or three visits for the survey, then one per batch |

| What                                                                           | Roughly how much                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| A named point of contact who can approve and sign for batches                  | 15–20 minutes per batch, a handful of batches a year |
| Sign-off on the custody paperwork, once, via the records coordinator and legal | One review cycle up front                            |
| A reviewer for the publish queue                                               | Self-paced; nothing expires waiting                  |
| A decision on Unit branding, disclaimer, and attribution language              | One conversation                                     |

What this does **not** ask for:

- No funding — hosting, equipment, software, and vendor transfer costs are mine.
- No staff time for scanning, sorting, indexing, or data entry.
- No IT resources, no network access, no agency devices, no accounts on agency systems.
- No use of the CAL FIRE seal or official marks without explicit approval. The site can carry a clear "unofficial volunteer project" disclaimer if the Chief prefers.

## Technology, standards, and cost

The stack is deliberately boring and cheap, and the Unit is never locked into it or into me.

| Piece                  | What it is                                            | Why                                                                    |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Netlify                | Static site hosting with a global CDN                 | Fast, inexpensive, nothing to patch or maintain                        |
| Supabase               | PostgreSQL catalog, authentication, file storage      | Standard Postgres — the data is portable to anything                   |
| Derivative image tiles | Pre-generated zoom levels for scans and photos        | Deep-zoom viewing without large downloads                              |
| OCR on ingest          | Searchable text extracted from every scanned document | Full-text search is what makes an archive usable                       |
| Off-site backup        | Nightly copy of the database and the master files     | A single point of failure is not acceptable for one-of-a-kind material |

**Preservation practice.** Masters are captured to archival specification — lossless TIFF for documents and photographs, following the federal FADGI guidelines the National Archives and Library of Congress use. Film and videotape go to a professional transfer vendor, not hobbyist equipment. Public files are derivatives; masters are never discarded to save space.

**Metadata.** The catalog schema maps to Dublin Core, so the whole thing can be exported and handed to the California State Archives or a professional archivist later without a migration project. Appendix B lists the fields.

**The Unit gets everything.** On request at any time, and automatically at the end of each phase: master files, a database export, and the documentation needed to stand the site up elsewhere. If I disappear tomorrow, the Unit has the archive.

**Cost.** Low tens of dollars a month at the scale this collection implies, absorbed by me. The one item that could become material is professional film and tape transfer, which is priced per reel. I will report counts and vendor quotes once the survey has established how much of it there is; if the volume warrants outside funding, that becomes a separate conversation about grants or a historical society partnership — not a bill to the Unit.

## Name, domain, and funding

**The domain.** A `.org` sets the right expectation: non-commercial, archival, and not posing as an official CAL FIRE property. Candidates:

- `nypfirearchive.org`
- `neufirecache.org`
- `nyparchives.org`
- `neufirearchive.org`

My own preference is `nypfirearchive.org` — it says exactly what the thing is, and NYP is what the people who worked here actually call it. `neufirecache.org` is the better name if the Unit wants something with more character to it. Either way the name, and whether the Unit's identity appears on it at all, is the Chief's call. If the answer is a plain disclaimer and no CAL FIRE marks, the site works fine that way.

**Funding.** I am absorbing the cost, and at the scale of hosting and a database that is not a meaningful number. Two things could change it: professional film and tape transfer, which is priced per reel and is the one genuinely expensive line item, and master file storage once it grows into the terabytes.

If that happens, the straightforward answer is a small public fundraiser — a GoFundMe or similar — to cover vendor transfer, hosting, and storage. Conditions I would hold myself to, stated here so they are on the record:

- Run by me as a private individual. Not by, for, or on behalf of CAL FIRE, and the Unit neither receives nor administers any funds.
- No use of the CAL FIRE name, seal, or official marks in any solicitation without written approval.
- Public accounting of what came in and what it paid for.
- None of it happens if the Chief would rather it did not. The project then runs at whatever pace my own budget allows, which is slower but not fatal.

The more durable long-term answer, if this grows, is a 501(c)(3) historical society or a partnership with an existing one — which is also what opens the door to real grant funding. The Indianapolis project was grant-funded, and California Revealed exists for precisely this kind of material. That is a later conversation, not part of this ask.

## Pace, and the honest constraint

I want to be direct about this rather than discover it later. I manage a development engineering team at ESO as my day job and work as a developer with Western Confluence Group. This project is evenings and weekends. What I can promise is steady, documented progress — not a delivery date, and not a pace anyone should build a plan around.

What that means in practice:

- Phases have scope, not deadlines. Each one finishes when it finishes.
- Progress is visible in the catalog and on the site, so nobody has to ask me for a status update.
- If I go quiet for a month, nothing is at risk — material is either back in the room or under a signed receipt with a return date.

**The off-ramp.** If my availability changes, or the Chief wants to stop, the Unit keeps the site, the database, the master files, and the documentation, and any material on loan comes back immediately. Everything is written down well enough that another volunteer, a contractor, or a professional archivist can pick it up without starting over. That is a design constraint, not a courtesy.

## Making it a living archive, not a digital storage room

A scanned box that nobody reads is only slightly better than a box nobody opens. The part of this project I care most about is the part that brings people back to it.

- **Feature stories.** Written pieces built from the archive, in the model of the Iron Mike story. One good story does more for the Unit's history than a thousand indexed documents.
- **Identify this photo.** A moderated queue of unidentified faces, apparatus, and locations. Retirees know things no finding aid will ever capture, and every contributor is credited.
- **Station pages.** Each station gets its own history, apparatus, and photographs. Current crews can see themselves in a line going back decades — that is a recruitment and morale asset, not just history.
- **Oral histories and family contributions.** Many of the best photographs of this Unit are in retirees' garages, not the archive room. A simple intake path with a plain-language release lets that material come in — scanned and returned, original kept by the family.

All of it runs through the same review gate as everything else. Nothing a member of the public submits appears on the site without approval.

## Risks, stated plainly

| Risk                                      | Assessment                                                          | Mitigation                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Damage or loss of irreplaceable originals | Real — though doing nothing also carries risk as the media degrades | Small batches, signed receipts, photographic condition record at pickup, single controlled storage location, fragile items scanned on-site or not at all |
| Sensitive material published by mistake   | The most serious exposure in this project                           | Default-private ingest, Unit holds the only approve action, conservative flagging, redaction, visible takedown path                                      |

| Risk                                                             | Assessment                                       | Mitigation                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Volunteer availability changes                                   | Likely at some point, given the day job          | Phase scope with no deadlines, full copy to the Unit at each phase, documentation written for a successor                                                             |
| Dependency on me or on the platform                              | A real concern for anything one volunteer builds | Standard Postgres and ordinary static hosting, no proprietary formats, Unit holds masters and exports                                                                 |
| Read as an official publication, or as a records-request channel | Likely unless addressed                          | Disclaimer and attribution approved by the Chief and PIO; clear language pointing formal records requests at the Department's Public Records Center, not at this site |

## If this is more than the Unit wants

This document describes the full version. It is not all-or-nothing, and I would rather do a smaller piece properly than push the Unit into something it is not comfortable with.

The parts separate cleanly:

- **Tier 1 — preservation only.** I scan and catalog, the Unit gets the master files and the database, and nothing is ever published anywhere. This is the floor, and it is still most of the value: the material stops being at risk and becomes searchable internally.
- **Tier 2 — preservation plus an internal site.** The same catalog and the same interface, behind a login, for Unit use only. Useful for training, anniversaries, press requests, and simply finding things.
- **Tier 3 — the full public archive.** Everything above, plus an approved public portion, the feature stories, and public contributions.

If the public piece is too far, say so and we do Tier 1 or Tier 2. If the whole thing is more than the Unit wants to take on right now, say so and nothing happens. The offer stands whenever it becomes useful, and if the Unit ever wants only the written inventory and none of the rest, that alone is worth doing. Any individual piece can be held — the public site, the outside contributions, the fundraising, the Unit branding — and the rest still works.

I am not going to be offended by a no, and I am not going to keep pushing. The material matters more than any particular version of this.

## What I am asking for now

Not approval of the whole program. Approval of two small, reversible steps, followed by a conversation.

1. **Permission to survey the room.** Escorted access for a few visits to produce a written, shelf-level inventory: what is on each shelf, in what format, and in what condition. The Unit keeps that document whatever happens next, and it is the only part of this proposal that is useful on its own.
2. **Permission to run one pilot batch.** Two to four boxes plus a small sample of at-risk media, out and back under signed custody paperwork the Unit's records coordinator and legal have approved. I scan it, catalog it, and build the site with that material in it.

3. **Then we meet.** The site exists but stays private — visible only to the Chief and whoever else the Unit wants in. Nothing is public. You look at the real thing, with real Unit material in it, and decide whether it goes further, goes public, or stops.

That means the Unit sees a working product before it commits to anything, and before a single item is visible outside the organization. If the answer after the pilot is no, the Unit keeps the inventory and the whole thing has cost it a few escorted visits and one review of some paperwork.

I would also welcome a pointer to whoever the Chief thinks should be in the room for this — the records coordinator, the PIO, a battalion chief with long institutional memory, or a retiree who already knows what is in that room.

## **Appendix A — Custody Receipt / Transfer of Materials**

One form, signed at release and again at return. Field list, ready to be turned into a real form by whoever owns forms at the Unit.

### **Header**

- Batch number (sequential, e.g. NEU-ARC-2026-004)
- Project name and authorizing agreement reference
- Unit and archive room location

### **Release**

- Date and time out
- Container count and container identifiers
- Description of materials, at folder level or item level for media
- Condition notes at release (per container)
- Photographs attached — yes/no, count, file reference
- Known restrictions or handling instructions
- Releasing employee: name, title, signature, date
- Receiving volunteer: name, signature, date
- Agreed return date
- Storage location and handling conditions during custody
- Statement that custody is temporary, ownership is unchanged, and onward transfer is prohibited

### **Return**

- Date and time returned
- Container count returned, reconciled against release
- Condition on return (per container), with any change from release noted
- Discrepancies — items missing, items found not on the manifest

- Returned Batch Report reference number
- Returning volunteer: name, signature, date
- Receiving employee: name, title, signature, date
- Unit acknowledgement that the batch is reconciled and closed

A running log of batch numbers and their status — out, returned, closed — answers "what is out of the room right now" on one page.

## Appendix B — The catalog record

Every digitized item gets a record with these fields. The Dublin Core column is what makes the catalog exportable to any standards-based archive later.

| Field                          | Purpose                                                                                           | Dublin Core |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Identifier                     | Permanent unique ID, never reused                                                                 | identifier  |
| Title                          | Supplied title, or a described one in brackets if the item has none                               | title       |
| Record group                   | Originating office — HQ, battalion, station, camp, program                                        | provenance  |
| Series                         | Incident records, station logs, photographs, moving image, maps, apparatus, rosters, publications | —           |
| Document type                  | Form or genre — ICS 209, daily log, photograph, map, film reel                                    | type        |
| Date or date range             | Exact where known, bracketed estimate where not                                                   | date        |
| Incident name and number       | The single most valuable access point for a fire unit                                             | subject     |
| Geography                      | Place name, and coordinates where they can be determined                                          | coverage    |
| People                         | Named or depicted, with a confidence note where identification is uncertain                       | subject     |
| Apparatus and resources        | Engine, dozer, crew, aircraft designations                                                        | subject     |
| Physical format and dimensions | Paper size, print size, film gauge, tape format, reel length                                      | format      |
| Condition                      | Physical state, and any preservation concern noted                                                | —           |
| Original container and folder  | Where it came from and where it went back — provenance is unrecoverable if this is lost           | provenance  |
| Scan specification             | Resolution, bit depth, color target, equipment, operator, date                                    | —           |
| OCR status                     | Not applicable, pending, complete, poor quality                                                   | —           |
| Review status and approver     | Unreviewed, flagged, approved, approved-with-redaction, withheld                                  | —           |
| Rights and access note         | Public, internal only, restricted, with the reason                                                | rights      |

| Field              | Purpose                                                      | Dublin Core |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Contributor credit | Who donated or identified it                                 | contributor |
| Description        | Free-text note — what it is, why it matters, what is unclear | description |

Uncertainty is recorded rather than hidden — "probably 1961" and "believed to be Battalion 2" are legitimate catalog values, marked as such. And the original container and folder location is never dropped, because it is the only thing that lets a future archivist reconnect a digital record to its physical context.